



## TOOLBOX TALK — WEEKLY SAFETY MEETING

Millwork | Carpentry | Interior Finishes | Material Handling

### WEEK 45

Date:  Supervisor:

Project / Job Name:

### TOPIC: Stair Railing & Baluster Installation Safety

#### OVERVIEW:

Stair railing installation takes place directly adjacent to one of the most hazardous locations on any construction site — the open stairway. Workers leaning to fasten newel posts, install balusters, and attach rail sections are inches from a drop that can be fatal. Temporary guardrails must remain in

#### TALKING POINTS — Read to Crew:

1. Temporary stair guardrails must not be removed until the permanent railing system is fully installed, fastened, and load-tested. The temptation to remove temporary protection because it is in the way during the installation of permanent rail is understandable but dangerous. Develop a procedure where only the section being directly worked on is temporarily unprotected, and that
2. Post-to-floor connections are the most critical structural element in a railing system. A post that is not properly fastened to the floor structure can pull free when a person leans on the rail — and people do lean on rails, hard, especially on stairs. The IBC requires that guardrails and handrails resist a 200-pound concentrated load applied in any direction. Test every post connection by
3. Baluster spacing is both an aesthetic and a safety requirement. The International Building Code requires baluster spacing such that a 4-inch sphere cannot pass through any opening. This requirement exists to prevent small children from getting their heads caught between balusters, which can result in strangulation. Measure baluster spacing consistently throughout the run. Do not
4. All hardware connections — carriage bolts, lag screws, metal brackets, and post bases — must be torqued to specification and checked for tightness. Rail hardware that is installed finger-tight and not properly torqued will loosen with vibration over time and eventually allow the rail to deflect or fail. Use a torque wrench or confirm that connection hardware is fully tightened by

#### DISCUSSION QUESTIONS — Ask Your Crew:

- Q1: What is our procedure for protecting the stairway opening while we install each section of permanent railing?  
Q2: Walk me through how you test a newel post connection after installation.

#### KEY SAFETY POINTS:

- Never remove temporary stair guards until permanent railings are tested
- Lean away from open stairways whenever fastening near the edge
- Test all post connections — they must withstand a minimum 200 lb lateral load
- Balusters must be spaced so a 4-inch sphere cannot pass through any opening
- Inspect all hardware connections — bolts, brackets, and post bases must be tight

*Crew sign-in sheet on page 2 — all 30 crew members sign on the following page.*



# CREW SIGN-IN SHEET

WEEK 45

By signing, I confirm I attended this toolbox talk and understand the topic discussed.

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